

DEBUNKED — SIKHISM SERIES
PART 2 OF 13

Miracles and Travels

Guru Nanak Dev Ji — what actually happened is deeper than the miracle.

Lovepreet Singh

An investigative debunk — 10 sakhis from the life of the first Guru, with named sources and Gurbani citations.

Sakhi and History

A *sakhi* is a testimony. The word comes from *sakshi* — witness. That is what the janamsakhis were meant to be: the community's testimony about the man who began it.

But testimony written down a century and a half after the fact, by people who never met the witness, is not the same thing as a record. The oldest janamsakhi manuscripts we have date from roughly the 1630s onward. Guru Nanak Dev Ji died in 1539. That is a gap of about a hundred years, spanning three or four generations of oral transmission, in a period with no Sikh chronicling tradition and considerable sectarian competition over who owned the memory.

Part 1 of this series dealt with claims other people make about us. This part is harder, because the claims are ours. Every sakhi in this book has been told to me by someone who loved me — by grandparents, by granthis, by teachers I respected. I am not writing against them. I am writing about the difference between two ways of holding a story.

A story held as literature can survive anything. A story held as history can be taken from you by a nineteen-year-old with an internet connection and forty minutes.

That is the whole of my argument, and it is a practical one. When we present the rotating Kaaba as a historical event to a generation that will check, we are not defending Sikhi. We are handing someone a lever. And when the lever is pulled and the Kaaba story goes, the young person does not stop at the Kaaba — because they were never told which parts were load-bearing and which were decoration, they throw out the whole house.

So this part sorts. Ten of the most famous sakhis attached to Guru Nanak Dev Ji, each taken apart with the same six steps, each measured against what the sources actually say and when they were written. Some hold up better than I expected. Some do not hold up at all. One or two turn out to have real, dated, verifiable history sitting directly underneath them that we have somehow stopped telling.

There is one thing I want to say before the first chapter, because it governs everything after it. **Guru Nanak Dev Ji did not claim miraculous powers. He refused them.** The Sidh Gosht — his own composition, in his own words, preserved in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji from ang 938 — is a long dialogue with yogis who possessed, or claimed, exactly the powers we have since attributed to him. He declined the argument and declined the powers.

Every miracle we hang on him is therefore not simply an untrue detail. It is a contradiction of the man's own stated position. We have spent five centuries crowning him with the thing he put down.

— Lovepreet Singh

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Every chapter follows the same six-step structure: **The Claim** • **Where It Came From** • **What the Janamsakhis Say** • **The Real History** • **The Debunk** • **The Honest Picture**.

my tongue speaks the names that people have made for You — but Your own name is sat naam

Debunked — Sikhism, Part 2 *Guru Arjan Dev Ji, Raag Maru, Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, ang 1083*

— THE MIRACLES ARE NAMES WE MADE; THE REAL NAME IS DEEPER

The Birth Prophecy and the Miracles at the Birth

THE CLAIM

When Nanak was born in 1469 at Talwandi in the house of Mehta Kalu Ji, the Brahmin Pandit Hardial cast the horoscope and announced that this child would be the Guru of Hindus and Muslims alike. The midwife Daultan said she had seen an unearthly light fill the room and had heard the sound of celestial music.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The annunciation is the single most standardised episode in world hagiography. A portent, a light, a wise man who reads the signs, a servant or shepherd who witnesses it: the pattern appears at the birth of the Buddha, of Mahavira, of Jesus, of the Prophet Muhammad, and of dozens of saints in every tradition on the subcontinent. It is a genre convention, and it is applied afterwards, by a community that already knows how the story ends.

In our case it enters through the janamsakhis, and their dates matter more than anything else in this book.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

Daultan the midwife hears no infant's cry but the sound of a grown man's laughter, and reports light in the room. Pandit Hardial casts the horoscope and prostrates. Rai Bular, the Muslim chief of the village, later recognises the child. The birth is placed at Rai Bhoi di Talwandi — today Nankana Sahib, in Pakistan.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — THE JANAMSAKHI SOURCES AND THEIR DATES

Puratan Janamsakhi — manuscript tradition, c. 1635 and later. **Bala Janamsakhi** — claims a companion's eyewitness authorship, but the surviving tradition is seventeenth-century and associated with the Hindali sect, which was hostile to the mainstream Panth. **Miharban Janamsakhi** — seventeenth century, from the Mina line, a rival claimant branch. **Gian Ratnavali**, attributed to Bhai Mani Singh Ji — early eighteenth century. Guru Nanak Dev Ji died in 1539. The earliest of these is roughly a century later, and each of the traditions was produced by a group with a stake in the outcome. W. H. McLeod's *Early Sikh Tradition: A Study of the Janam-sakhis* (Clarendon, 1980) remains the standard critical study.

What is solidly attested is a good deal more ordinary and a good deal more interesting. He was born in 1469 at Rai Bhoi di Talwandi. His father, Mehta Kalu, was a *patwari* — a village revenue accountant — in the employ of **Rai Bular Bhatti**, the local Muslim landlord. His mother was Mata Tripta. His elder sister **Bebe Nanaki**, married to Jai Ram at Sultanpur Lodhi, is the person who repeatedly moved his life forward.

Even the date is not what we think. The gurpurab is celebrated on Kartik Puranmashi, in November. A substantial body of scholarship, working from the earliest sources, places the birth in **Vaisakh** — April. The Kartik date became fixed through later custom. We are, in all likelihood, celebrating on the wrong month, and it has not damaged the celebration in the slightest, which is itself a useful lesson about what these things are for.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

- **The chain of transmission does not exist.** Daultan's testimony reaches us through a manuscript written roughly 150 years after she would have died, with no named intermediary. That is not a weak source. It is not a source.
- **The form gives it away.** Light at the birth, music in the air, a wise man reading portents — if the same three elements appear at the birth of every founder in every tradition, they are telling us about the genre, not about the night.

- **The horoscope contradicts the man.** This is the deepest problem. The claim asks a Brahmin's astrological reading to certify the authority of a teacher whose life's work included refusing the janeu at nine, dismissing ritual specialists, and writing compositions that strip auspicious days of any magical power. Validating Guru Nanak Dev Ji by horoscope is like validating a fire-safety officer by the quality of his fireworks.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Take the light out of the room and look at who is actually standing in it.

A Hindu Khatri family works for a Muslim landlord in a Punjabi village. The father keeps the revenue accounts. The son turns out strange — gives away the money he is sent to trade with, refuses the sacred thread, worries everyone. The father complains. And the person who defends the boy, repeatedly, over years, and eventually grants land to the family, is **Rai Bular** — the Muslim.

That is the annunciation. Not a Brahmin with a chart, but a Muslim chief who looked at a Hindu clerk's difficult son and saw something worth protecting. Rai Bular is a real, locally documented figure, and the land his descendants held is a matter of record. He recognised Guru Nanak Dev Ji from across the religious line, decades before the man said anything about Hindus and Muslims.

The whole argument of the life is already there, in the first thing that happens. We replaced it with a horoscope.

Mecca and the Turning of the Kaaba

THE CLAIM

Arriving at Mecca, Guru Nanak Dev Ji lay down to sleep with his feet pointing towards the Kaaba. The qazi seized his feet and dragged them away in anger — and whichever direction the feet were turned, the stone Kaaba itself swung round to stand in front of them.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

Here I have to correct something I assumed before I checked. This is not a late accretion. The episode appears in **Bhai Gurdas Ji's Var 1** — our earliest Sikh narrative source, written by the scribe of the Adi Granth, within roughly a century of the events. The mullah is named. The turning is described.

That means the honest question is not "when was this invented?" but "what kind of text is a var, and what did its author think he was doing?"

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

He arrives in the dress of a pilgrim — blue clothes, a staff, a book under his arm, a prayer mat, a water jug. He sleeps with his feet towards the Kaaba. Jeevan, in some versions Rukn-ud-Din, wakes him and demands to know how he dares point his feet at the house of God. He answers: *then turn my feet in the direction where God is not*. The building follows.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — WHAT A VAR IS

Bhai Gurdas Ji's *Var 1* runs to forty-nine pauris and covers Guru Nanak Dev Ji's mission and travels, including Mecca, Baghdad, and the debates with the Nath yogis. Bhai Gurdas Ji (d. 1636) was the scribe of the Adi Granth and the nephew of Guru Amar Das Ji — as close to the centre of the tradition as a person can be. But a *var* is a heroic ballad. Its purpose is to praise, and its conventions include magnification. Reading a var as though it were a court chronicle is a category error, and it is our error, not his.

Could he have gone to Mecca? Probably, yes. Punjab was connected to the Hijaz by heavily used trade and pilgrimage routes, and Punjabi Muslims made hajj routinely. Entry to the Haram was restricted to Muslims, but the European traveller Ludovico di Varthema reached Mecca in disguise in 1503, which shows the restriction was porous in exactly this period. Travelling with Mardana, a Muslim companion, in the dress of a faqir, arrival is not difficult to imagine.

One source must be dropped from our arguments. The so-called *Siyahto Baba Nanak Fakir*, a diary supposedly kept by one Haji Tajuddin and lodged in a library at Medina around 1512, is quoted constantly in popular Sikh writing as independent proof. It has never been produced, catalogued, photographed or examined by any scholar in any language. We should stop citing it.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

The Kaaba is a masonry cube roughly fifteen metres high, standing on foundations, in the most continuously observed courtyard on earth. It does not rotate.

And this is the rare claim where the argument from silence is overwhelming. Islamic scholarship documents the Haram in extraordinary detail — every repair, every flood, every reconstruction, every dispute over the Black Stone, across fourteen centuries. If the Kaaba had physically moved in front of pilgrims, it would be the best-attested event in Islamic history. It appears in no Islamic source at all.

But the fatal objection is theological, not physical. Look at the reply again: *turn my feet in the direction where God is not*. That sentence works only if God is in every direction and no place is privileged. If the building then

chases his feet, the building has just been treated as the location of God — which is precisely the idea the sentence was demolishing. **The miracle refutes the punchline.** A story cannot make its own point and destroy it in the same breath.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

The line is the miracle. It always was.

A Punjabi faqir walks into the holiest enclosure in Islam, is challenged by its custodian, and answers with a single question that leaves nowhere for the challenge to stand. He does not argue that the Kaaba is unimportant. He does not insult it. He points out that a God who can be offended by the direction of a sleeping man's feet is too small to be God, and he does it in one sentence, in someone else's sacred space, without raising his voice.

Bhai Gurdas Ji, writing a hundred years later in the ballad form of his time, added a rotating building because that is what ballads do. We can keep his poem and still say plainly that the stone stayed where it was. The sentence needs no help.

Panja Sahib and Wali Kandhari's Boulder

THE CLAIM

At Hasan Abdal, the Muslim faqir Wali Kandhari, living on the hill, cut off the water of his spring out of spite and then rolled a huge boulder down at Guru Nanak Dev Ji. The Guru raised his open palm and stopped the rock, leaving the print of his hand pressed into it, and a spring of water burst from the place.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

Unlike the Mecca episode, this one is not in the earliest layer. It is absent from the oldest janamsakhi material and enters the tradition late. The shrine's prominence is later still: Gurdwara Panja Sahib as a major institution dates from the patronage of **Hari Singh Nalwa** and the Sikh empire's expansion into the north-west in the 1820s and 1830s. The site became important, and then the site's story became important.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

Mardana, thirsty, is sent three times up the hill to ask the faqir for water and is refused, the third time with contempt for his master. The Guru lifts a stone at his feet and water flows; the faqir's spring on the hill runs dry; the faqir, enraged, pushes down the boulder; the Guru stops it with his hand.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — HASAN ABDAL

A town at the foot of the hills on the Grand Trunk Road, about forty kilometres from Rawalpindi. It has been a staging post for as long as there has been traffic on that road, and the reason is water: the site has strong natural karst springs fed by the limestone hills behind it. Those springs are why Mughal emperors built gardens there, why a settlement exists at all, and why any traveller in any century would have stopped. They were flowing long before 1469 and they are flowing now.

That he passed through the region is entirely plausible — the route north-west towards Kabul and beyond runs directly through it. Baba Wali Kandhari is remembered locally as a Sufi of the area, and his shrine sits on the hill above.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

- **The spring was already there.** This is the quiet problem with the story. Hasan Abdal exists *because* of its springs. A miracle that produces water at the one place in the district famous for water is a miracle with nothing to do.
- **Hand and footprints in stone are a global relic-form.** The subcontinent and the wider Muslim and Buddhist world hold hundreds of them — footprints of Vishnu at Gaya, of the Buddha across Asia, of Adam in Sri Lanka, of the Prophet in several cities. When a form is that common, the form is the evidence of the form, not of the event.
- **Rock does not take a handprint.** Stone deforms by fracture, not by impression. A palm-shaped hollow in rock is either carved, or a natural weathering feature that the eye completes — the same faculty that finds faces in clouds.
- **The story is late and the site is later.** Absent from the earliest sources, prominent from the 1820s.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

There is a real moral image inside this sakhi and it is not about a rock. It is about a man on a hill controlling the water and refusing it to thirsty people below. In the dry north-west, that is not a metaphor; it is a description of how water has been fought over for as long as there have been settlements there. The story says: holiness that hoards water is not holiness. That teaching does not need the boulder.

And there is something else at Hasan Abdal we have almost stopped telling, which is documented to the day.

On **30 October 1922**, a train carrying Sikh prisoners was scheduled to pass through Hasan Abdal without stopping. The sangat at Panja Sahib had prepared langar for them. When the authorities refused to halt the train, Sikhs lay down across the railway line in front of it. The train did not stop in time. **Bhai Karam Singh** and **Bhai Partap Singh** were killed under it, and the train halted, and the prisoners were fed. It is remembered as the Saka Panja Sahib.

Two men stopped a train with their bodies at that site, and we tell the story about the palm print.

The Cobra That Shaded His Face

THE CLAIM

As a boy, sent out to graze the buffaloes, Guru Nanak Dev Ji fell asleep in a field. When the sun moved onto his face, a black cobra came, raised its hood over him, and stood holding the shade until he woke. Rai Bular, the chief of the village, saw it with his own eyes.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The serpent canopy is one of the oldest pieces of visual grammar in South Asia. Mucalinda, the naga king, raises his hood over the meditating Buddha in the rain. Shesha spreads his hoods over Vishnu. The seven-headed naga arches over Parshvanatha in Jain sculpture. Before the story was ever told about Guru Nanak Dev Ji, every viewer in the subcontinent already knew what a snake-hood above a sleeping figure meant: *this one is marked*.

The image was available. It was applied.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

The janamsakhis place the episode at Talwandi, in the boy's grazing years, with Rai Bular riding past and witnessing it. Later retellings drift the location — Sialkot is common in modern versions. That drift is worth noticing on its own: a story firmly anchored to a real event does not change districts between tellings.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — WHAT A COBRA ACTUALLY DOES

Naja naja, the Indian cobra, is ectothermic — it has no internal temperature regulation and must manage heat by behaviour. In the middle of a Punjab summer day it seeks shade, crevices and burrows; direct sun for a prolonged period is dangerous to it. Hooding is not a resting posture. It is a threat display: energetically expensive, held for seconds or minutes, and abandoned as soon as the threat passes. A cobra standing motionless in full sun, hood spread, for the length of a boy's afternoon nap, is behaving in a way no cobra behaves.

What is real here is **Rai Bular Bhatti**. He was the Muslim chief of Rai Bhoi di Talwandi, the employer of Mehta Kalu, a locally documented figure whose family held land in the area for generations afterwards. Sikh tradition consistently remembers him as among the first to recognise the child's stature and as the man who defended him against his own father's exasperation.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

The animal cannot do it, and the witness cannot be reached. Rai Bular died in the sixteenth century; the earliest text reporting what he saw was written in the seventeenth, by someone with no stated line of transmission back to him. Between the event and the page lie four or five generations of retelling in a community that had every reason to remember its founder as marked from childhood.

Add the borrowed iconography and the wandering location, and there is very little left standing. This is not a case where the details have been exaggerated. It is a case where a ready-made image from the surrounding religious culture has been fitted onto a childhood we know almost nothing about.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Strip out the snake and Rai Bular is still standing there, and he is the better story.

A Muslim landlord watches his Hindu accountant's son grow up odd — giving away goods, refusing rituals, sitting in fields when he should be working. The father wants the boy disciplined. The landlord protects him instead, and keeps protecting him, and grants land to the family.

Everything Guru Nanak Dev Ji would later say about religious boundaries had already been done to him, quietly, by a Muslim, before he said a word about it. The first person to see what he was did not share his religion. That is not a decoration on the life. It is the thesis of the life, arriving before the life starts.

We swapped it for a snake we borrowed from someone else's iconography.

Three Days in the Kali Bein

THE CLAIM

At Sultanpur Lodhi, Guru Nanak Dev Ji went into the Kali Bein to bathe and vanished beneath the water for three days. He was taken to the court of Akal Purakh, given the cup of amrit, and sent back. When he surfaced, his first words were: "na ko hindu na musalman."

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

This is the hinge of the whole biography and it is present across every janamsakhi tradition — Puratan, Bala, Miharban, Gian Ratnavali. Nothing else in his life is so uniformly attested. The site itself returned to public attention in our own time through the campaign begun in 2000 by Sant Balbir Singh Seechewal to clean the badly polluted Bein, which is one of the more genuinely remarkable things any Sikh has done in the last fifty years.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

He goes to bathe at dawn, as he does every day. He does not come out. His clothes are on the bank. The town searches the water and finds nothing; his employer's men drag the stream. On the third day he reappears. He is silent for a further day, and then speaks the sentence. He gives away his possessions, resigns his post, and leaves.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — SULTANPUR LODHI, C. 1499

He was about thirty. Through his brother-in-law Jai Ram he held a real job: keeper of the *modikhana*, the state granary and store, for **Daulat Khan Lodhi**, the governor. He was married, with two sons. Mardana, the Muslim rabab player from his own village, was with him. This is the most settled and conventional period of his life — a government storekeeper with a family and a salary — and it is the period he walked away from.

Whatever occurred, the outcome is fixed and datable in its consequences: he left the job, left the town, and began the travels. Every janamsakhi agrees that a three-day disappearance preceded the change.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Three days submerged is not a borderline claim. Human beings lose consciousness within a few minutes without air; the world records in static apnea, achieved by trained specialists breathing pure oxygen beforehand, sit in the region of minutes, not days. There is no version of this that is physiologically open.

But notice what the sources actually say, because the difference is important. They say he **disappeared** for three days. They do not require him to have been underwater for three days. A man who walks into a river at dawn, walks out somewhere else, and spends three days alone before returning is doing something entirely possible — and the janamsakhi accounts, read plainly, support that as easily as they support the other reading. The submersion is an inference that hardened into a claim.

The famous sentence needs one further correction, and it is uncomfortable. "**Na ko hindu na musalman**" is **not in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji**. It comes to us from the janamsakhi tradition, not from Gurbani. The line closest to it in scripture is Bhagat Kabir Ji's "*na hum hindu na musalman*" at **ang 1136** — the epigraph of Part 1 of this series. The most quoted sentence in Sikh history is not among the recorded words of the man we quote it from.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Something happened at Sultanpur. A thirty-year-old civil servant with a wife, two sons, a salary and a respectable brother-in-law disappeared for three days and came back a different person — then resigned, gave

away what he had, and spent the next two decades on the road. Every source we possess, from every rival faction, agrees on that shape. In a tradition where the factions agree on very little, that unanimity is worth more than any single detail inside it.

And the content of what he brought out is not a matter of testimony at all. It is printed on **ang 1**. The Mul Mantar and Japji Sahib open the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, and anyone can read them tonight.

We do not need him to have breathed underwater. We need only to notice that a man in a secure government post walked out of it at thirty, which most people find considerably harder to imagine.

Sidh Gosht on the Summit of Sumer Parbat

THE CLAIM

During his travels Guru Nanak Dev Ji ascended in his physical body to the summit of Sumer Parbat — identified with Mount Kailash — where the Siddh yogis have lived for thousands of years in deathless bodies. The conversation he had with them there became the bani known as Sidh Gosht.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The janamsakhis place a meeting with the Siddhs on a mountain. The identification of that mountain with Kailash is a later gloss, added by retellers who wanted a location that could be pointed to on a map. The immortality of the yogis is drawn from the Nath tradition's own claims about itself — the Naths held that their masters, Gorakhnath and Machhindarnath among them, had conquered death.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

He climbs beyond the snow line. He finds an assembly of Siddhs seated in a place no ordinary body can reach. They question him about the world below and about who his master is. He answers, at length, and the answers become the composition.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — SIDH GOSHT AND THE NATHS

Sidh Gosht sits in Raag Ramkali, **angs 938 to 946** of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji — seventy-three stanzas of formal dialogue with Nath yogis. The Naths were not a legend. They were the dominant renunciate order of fifteenth and sixteenth-century Punjab and the hills, with major establishments at **Tilla Jogian**, at **Gorakhmata** in the Himalayan foothills — renamed Nanakmata after his visit — and at **Achal Batala**, where the tradition records his best-known encounter with them. These are ordinary places, reachable on foot, and several are still standing.

Sumeru or Meru is the cosmological world-axis of Hindu, Buddhist and Jain cosmology. It is not a peak that anyone has surveyed; asking for its coordinates is a category error. **Kailash**, the mountain later substituted for it, is 6,638 metres, has never been summited by anyone in history, and is closed to climbing by agreement out of respect for its sanctity.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

- **The destination is mythological.** Sumer Parbat is a cosmological structure, not a geographical one. Reading it literally is like asking which country heaven borders.
- **If you substitute Kailash, the claim gets worse, not better.** It then requires an unclimbed 6,638-metre Himalayan summit to have been reached in the sixteenth century in ordinary clothes.
- **The deathless yogis are the Naths' claim about themselves** — a claim Guru Nanak Dev Ji spent the composition disputing.
- **The sakhi contradicts the bani it is attached to.** This is the heart of it. *Sidh Gosht* is, from beginning to end, a refusal to accept miraculous power as the measure of spiritual attainment. The Siddhs press him on *ridhi-sidhi*, the supernatural attainments, and he sets them aside as worthless beside the Name. Wrapping that composition inside a story where he arrives by supernatural means turns the author into the thing he is arguing against.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

The real encounters are better documented than almost anything else in his life, because the transcript survives in his own words in our own scripture.

He went to the places where the Naths actually were — Achal Batala, Gorakhmata, the hill establishments — and argued with the most formidable renunciate order of his age on their own ground. They were not straw men. They had institutional power, popular awe, centuries of prestige, and a coherent philosophy. He took them on in public, in Punjabi, in verse, and the exchange is preserved across nine angas.

His core position in it is the one that made Sikhi different from everything around it: you do not have to leave the world to reach God. The householder, working and earning honestly, is not spiritually inferior to the ascetic on the mountain.

Which makes the sakhi doubly strange. To honour the man who said *you do not need the mountain*, we put him on the mountain.

Eminabad — Bhai Lalo's Bread and Malik Bhago's Feast

THE CLAIM

At Eminabad, Guru Nanak Dev Ji took Bhai Lalo's coarse millet bread in one hand and a dish from Malik Bhago's thirty-six-course feast in the other, and squeezed both. Milk ran from the poor carpenter's bread; blood dripped from the rich official's food.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The janamsakhi tradition, and it has thrived because it is superb teaching material. It is instantly graspable, it needs no theology to explain it, and it lands with a child as hard as with an adult. It is also, in the strict sense, a parable that has been read as a report.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

Guru Nanak Dev Ji stays with Bhai Lalo, a low-caste carpenter, and eats his plain food. Malik Bhago, the local revenue official, is offended that a visiting holy man has ignored his own lavish table, and summons him. Asked to explain, the Guru performs the squeeze. Bhago's wealth, he says, is wrung from the labour of others; Lalo's bread is honest earning.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — EMINABAD, 1520-21

Eminabad, then Saidpur, was sacked by **Babur's** army during the invasions that ended with Panipat in 1526. Guru Nanak Dev Ji was there, and he wrote about it. The hymns known as **Babarvani** — Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, **angs 360, 417–418 and 722–723** — are his eyewitness account of the destruction of the town, the killing, and the treatment of its women. He calls the invading force a marriage party of sin. He also puts the question directly to God, and does not soften it: why was this permitted?

Historians of the period use the Babarvani as a source. It is one of the very few descriptions of the Mughal invasions written from underneath by a named, datable contemporary who was standing in the town when it happened.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Bread does not contain milk. Cooked food does not contain the blood of the labourers whose work paid for it. The squeeze is a physical impossibility, and it is obviously an image — the kind of compressed visual metaphor that oral teaching runs on. Someone, at some point, stopped saying "it was as if" and the "as if" never came back.

Neither Bhai Lalo nor Malik Bhago is independently attested outside Sikh tradition. That does not make them fictional — a carpenter and a mid-level revenue officer in a small Punjabi town are exactly the sort of people who leave no other trace — but it means the episode rests entirely on sources written a century or more later.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

The teaching is not in doubt for a moment, because it is in his own recorded words rather than in a sakhi. *Kirat karo* — earn by honest work — is stated plainly across his compositions, alongside the sharpest condemnations of exploitation in the scripture of any tradition of that century.

But consider what else Eminabad gives us, and what we have chosen to tell instead.

In the same town, in the same few years, a Punjabi poet watched an imperial army destroy a civilian population and wrote it down — the burning, the dead, the women dragged from their homes — and put it into a scripture that is still read aloud daily, five centuries later. At almost the same moment, the emperor responsible was

composing his own memoirs of the same campaign from the other side of the sword. Both texts survive. Both can be read today.

We have a first-hand account of a Mughal invasion written from below, by our own founder, and we tell the one about the bread.

The Baghdad Inscription and the Journey Through the Netherworlds

THE CLAIM

An ancient stone inscription survives at Baghdad which directly proves that Guru Nanak Dev Ji was there. And it was at Baghdad that he ascended and descended in his physical body through the seven netherworlds and the seven skies, taking the son of the local pir with him.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

Two separate things have been fused here, and they need separating.

The travel itself is early: **Bhai Gurdas Ji's Var 1** records that Baba Nanak reached Baghdad with Mardana and stayed outside the city, and describes a discourse with a pir there. The **inscription**, by contrast, entered Sikh consciousness in **March 1917**, when Sikh soldiers serving with the Indian Army during the Mesopotamian campaign found a stone with an Arabic text near a shrine and read it as a record of the Guru's visit. It has been treated as decisive proof ever since. The **patal-akash journey** comes from the janamsakhis.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

Mardana gives the call to prayer and the city falls silent. The pir — called Dastgir or Bahlol in different versions — challenges him about the nature of creation. To answer, the Guru takes the pir's son by the hand and travels with him through the seven underworlds and seven heavens, returning in an instant with a bowl of sacred food as evidence.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — THE BAGHDAD STONE

The inscription is set into a wall inside the reputed tomb of Bahlol, near the tombs of Sitt Zubayda and Yusha' Nabi, between the modern airport and Baghdad West station. Its date figures were read in the earliest photographs as **927 AH (1520–21)**; the second figure was subsequently damaged, and the date is now commonly read as **917 AH (1511–12)** — nine years apart, in two different journeys under any reconstruction of the itinerary. The text has been examined and published in scholarly literature, including in the *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society*, and both its reading and its dating remain disputed.

Punjab and Baghdad were connected by long-established trade and pilgrimage routes, and Punjabi merchants used them. A faqir travelling west with a Muslim companion is not an extraordinary proposition. The travel is plausible and it is attested within a century by a serious source.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

- **A disputed inscription is not "direct proof."** Its date is read two ways nine years apart, its text is contested, and it surfaced in a wall in 1917. Every one of those facts individually weakens it; together they disqualify the word "proof."
- **Even at its strongest it would prove the wrong thing.** An inscription demonstrates that someone erected a memorial. Memorials are erected long after the fact, and by people with their own reasons.
- **Drop the diary.** The *Siyahito Baba Nanak Fakir*, supposedly kept by Haji Tajuddin and lodged at Medina, is quoted everywhere online as independent confirmation. No scholar has ever seen it. It should not appear in our arguments.
- **The netherworld journey inverts his own line.** *Patal* and *akash* are the levels of Indian cosmology, and Guru Nanak Dev Ji uses them himself — in Japji Sahib, pauri 22, **ang 5**: "*paataalaa paataal lakh aagaasaa aagaas*", "there are hundreds of thousands of netherworlds beneath netherworlds, and skies above skies."

The entire point of the line is that the count cannot be reached or known. Using it as evidence that he toured the place is a precise reversal of what he wrote.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

He probably did travel west. Bhai Gurdas Ji says so within a hundred years, and Bhai Gurdas Ji is not a careless witness. The routes existed, the companion was a Muslim, and a wandering faqir was an unremarkable sight on those roads.

What we do not have is proof, and we do not need to manufacture any. This is the part that concerns me most in the whole book: **a tradition that invents evidence for a claim that may well be true does more damage to that claim than its opponents ever could.** When the Baghdad stone is finally settled one way or the other by people who read Arabic epigraphy for a living, the ones who staked everything on it will have to move, and they will take the plausible parts with them when they go.

Say what we can support. He very likely reached Baghdad. There is a stone there that some read as remembering him. The seven netherworlds are a figure of speech that he wrote himself, and he wrote it to say that the universe is beyond counting — not to file a travel report.

The Geographic Impossibility of the Four Udasis

THE CLAIM

In four great journeys over about twenty-one years, Guru Nanak Dev Ji walked some 28,000 kilometres — in many tellings 50,000 — reaching Assam, Sri Lanka, Tibet, Mecca, Medina and Baghdad, on foot.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The map with four coloured arrows radiating from Punjab is a twentieth-century object. So is the kilometre total. The janamsakhis describe journeys; they do not organise them into four numbered udasis with a mileage figure attached. That framework was imposed later, by modern writers building a coherent itinerary out of scattered episodes, and the distance was then computed by joining the claimed sites with lines.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

They say he travelled a great deal, in several directions, over many years, with Mardana for much of it. They do not agree with each other about the routes, the order, or the destinations. Different traditions send him to different places in different sequences.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — THE FIXED POINTS

Born **1469**. At Sultanpur Lodhi until about **1499**. At Saidpur/Eminabad during Babur's assault, **1520–21** — fixed by his own Babarvani, not by tradition. Settled at **Kartarpur** from about 1521–22 and lived there for roughly his last eighteen years, farming, holding sangat and composing. Died **22 September 1539**. The travelling window is therefore about 1500 to 1521 — twenty-one years at the outside.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Let me begin by conceding the objection everyone reaches for first, because it is the weak one.

The distance is not impossible. Twenty-eight thousand kilometres over twenty-one years averages under four kilometres a day. Put another way: at a sustainable twenty-two kilometres on a walking day, the total needs about 1,200 walking days — a little over three years of actual walking, leaving eighteen years for stays, teaching and rest. Medieval pilgrims and traders covered comparable ground. Arithmetic does not refute this claim, and we should stop pretending it does.

What fails is everything else.

- **The itineraries contradict each other.** The janamsakhi traditions do not agree on where he went or in what order. McLeod's *Early Sikh Tradition* (1980) works through the discrepancies in detail. A route reconstructed by combining incompatible accounts is not a route; it is a composite.
- **Many sites are attested only by a later gurdwara.** A shrine built in the eighteenth or nineteenth century marks where Sikhs later lived and travelled, which followed migration, military service and trade — not necessarily where the Guru walked.
- **Some destinations cannot be visited.** Sumer Parbat is cosmological. Kailash has never been climbed.
- **The dates collide.** The Baghdad inscription is read as 1511–12 or 1520–21; the Mecca journey is popularly dated 1518–21; and he is independently placed at Eminabad in 1520–21 by his own hymns, settling Kartarpur immediately afterwards. These cannot all be accommodated in one itinerary, and the usual response is to quietly stop counting.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

He travelled, extensively, for about two decades. That is attested by Bhai Gurdas Ji and by every janamsakhi tradition, and it is not seriously questioned by anyone. What cannot be defended is the poster: the four arrows, the pinned sites, the total in kilometres.

And the number is doing something we should notice. It converts his greatness into mileage — as though the achievement were the walking, and the further he walked the greater he was.

He spent his last eighteen years in one small place on the Ravi. At Kartarpur he farmed his own land, ate with whoever came, established the practice of langar and sangat in a working settlement, tested and chose a successor from outside his family, and composed a great deal of what we now read. **Sikhi was not built on the road. It was built after he stopped walking.**

We made a poster of the journeys and left out the eighteen years that produced the religion.

Jyoti-Jot and the Flowers Beneath the Sheet

THE CLAIM

When Guru Nanak Dev Ji passed away at Kartarpur, his Hindu followers wished to cremate the body and his Muslim followers to bury it. They argued through the night. In the morning the sheet was lifted and the body was gone — only flowers lay beneath it. Each community took half: the Hindus burned theirs, the Muslims buried theirs.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The janamsakhi tradition, where it functions as the closing episode of the genre — a resolution story, designed to answer the question the whole life had raised. It is the perfect ending, which is a reason to look at it carefully rather than a reason not to.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE JANAMSAKHIS SAY

He asks both communities to place flowers beside him — in some versions, whichever group's flowers remain fresh by morning may perform the rites. He covers himself with a sheet. In the morning both sets of flowers are fresh, the body has gone, and the sheet is divided.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — KARTARPUR, 22 SEPTEMBER 1539

At Gurdwara Darbar Sahib Kartarpur, in Narowal district, Pakistan, there stand today both a **samadhi** and a **grave** — a Hindu memorial and a Muslim one, side by side, at the same site. The Ravi repeatedly flooded and shifted its course over the centuries, destroying the earlier structures, which were rebuilt more than once. The succession had already been settled before his death: **Bhai Lehna**, a disciple, had been installed as Guru Angad Dev Ji, and Guru Nanak Dev Ji's own sons, Sri Chand and Lakhmi Das, were passed over.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

A body does not become flowers. But the more interesting point is that the physical evidence at Kartarpur quietly contradicts the story it is supposed to support.

If the body had vanished and been replaced by flowers divided between two communities, we would expect one shared memorial, or a story about the flowers. What actually stands there is a grave and a samadhi — two full memorials, one for each rite, built side by side. That is not what a miracle leaves behind. It is what a **negotiated settlement** leaves behind: two communities with a genuine claim on the same man, who could not agree, and who resolved it by each doing their own thing in the same place and continuing to live next to each other.

That is a harder and better ending than the flowers, and it is standing in Narowal district where anyone can go and look at it.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Notice what the flowers story is actually about. Two communities each insisting he was theirs — which is the exact claim Part 1 of this series spent ten chapters answering. The absorption argument does not begin in a nineteenth-century pamphlet or a twentieth-century political speech. It begins at his funeral, among people who loved him.

His own answer had been given decades earlier and was not ambiguous. He was neither, and the path he had opened was neither.

But the real ending of this life is not the funeral at all. It is the succession, and it is the most radical thing he ever did.

He tested his followers over years. He passed over both of his own sons — in sixteenth-century Punjab, where authority descended through the male line as a matter of course. He chose a disciple, renamed him **Angad**, "of my own limb," installed him publicly, and then *bowed to him*.

A founder who makes succession a matter of merit rather than blood, and who demonstrates it by placing himself below the man he has appointed, has done something structurally extraordinary. It is the decision that made ten Gurus possible instead of one family business, and therefore the decision that made everything in Part 3 of this series possible.

The flowers are a beautiful story about two communities. The bow is the reason there was anything left to argue over.

What Part 2 Tried to Do

The ten sakhis in this part converge on one point: **Guru Nanak Dev Ji's greatness does not stand on miracles.**

Turning the Kaaba, stopping a boulder with a palm, a cobra holding shade, three days alive under water, immortal yogis on a summit, milk and blood wrung from bread, a bodily tour of the netherworlds, twenty-eight thousand kilometres on foot, a corpse become flowers — these are layers of the janamsakhi tradition. They are not historical events, and several of them contradict the compositions they are attached to.

He refused the miraculous himself, in his own words, in Sidh Gosht, on ang 1 we can open tonight. He staked his authority on the Name and on nothing else. The Guru who put down *ridhi-sidhi* is the same Guru whose forehead we keep trying to crown with them.

None of this makes the janamsakhis worthless. They are our memory and our devotional literature, and some of them are magnificent as literature. But **a janamsakhi is not a chronicle**, and the confusion between the two is not harmless. It is the specific weakness that a hostile reader will always find first, and it is the reason a young Sikh who discovers that one sakhi does not hold sometimes concludes that nothing does.

Keep both, and keep them in their own places. The sakhi as spiritual literature. The historical record as history. That is not a loss of faith; it is a refusal to build faith on ground we know is soft.

And what is left when the decoration comes off is not thin. It is a man who walked out of a secure job at thirty, argued down the most powerful renunciate order of his century in public verse, stood in a sacked town and wrote down what an emperor's army did to civilians, farmed his own land for eighteen years, ate with everyone, and handed his authority to someone else's son rather than his own.

His real and permanent bequest is his bani — Japji Sahib, Asa di Var, the Babarvani, Sidh Gosht, the Mul Mantar that opens the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji at ang 1. Those are his own words, preserved, checkable, and read aloud somewhere in the world at this moment.

Miracles fade with the age that needed them. Bani stays awake.

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What's Next

Part 3 turns to the eight Gurus between Nanak and Gobind — **The Eight Silent Gurus: Sakhi and History**. The invention of a script. Twelve years of penance on one leg. An emperor in the langar queue. A city given as dowry. A Sufi's hand on a foundation brick. A smile on a hot iron plate. Fifty-two kings and a cloak with fifty-two tails. A herb that cured a prince. A touch that cured smallpox. A headless body that walked. The same six-step structure. The same care. The same honesty. The same respect.

— *End of Part 2* —